

The all-reaching water lily

Tenochtitlan and city building in the Nahua Empire

Tenochtitlan, center of the Mexica Empire is called by some the Venice of America. Although its beauty is nowadays buried under Mexico City, its legend lives on, passed through myths and stories of the wars it fought and the golden age it knew. By looking at a map of Tenochtitlan Altepētl as my primary source, and Camilla Townsend's *Fifth Sun* as my secondary source, I will take my turn in narrating the story of this sophisticated marvel of architecture. In this essay, I argue that Tenochtitlan sources its power from a structural organization of its spaces that are interconnected in a meaningful and unique way. This analysis is made possible by the intent of conveying richness and powerfulness the map illustrates by bringing together various aspects of the city's life, along with the more accurate historical precisions brought by Townsend. To order the narration, I will dissect the city like a flower, which the map closely resembles, by first starting with its center then moving outwards while linking thematically the different parts I examine. In this fashion, first will come the administrative and religious center of power and the socio-economic dynamic it brings to the city, then I will turn to the incorporation of aquatic infrastructure and axis of communication as vital aspects of the city, and finally I will delve into Tenochtitlan as the head of the Mexica Empire and its relation with the outer world.

First of all, the city of Tenochtitlán is portrayed as a structured flower with symmetrical patterns centralizing power at its very center. Indeed, at the very center of the very center of the map stands a human figure. It is one of the few depicted characters, but stands out by its size and centrality, but also because its head seems to be missing. In its place, a temple: a building several times bigger than surrounding houses elevated between towers and thick walls separating this sacred space from the rest of the city. Here appears one of the more salient indistinctions: the fusion of administrative and religious activities. The head of the Empire residing among the most important religious edifices shows the interconnectedness of these elements. Furthermore, the pious organization of spaces in the city goes beyond the center: the city itself, visible by the agglomeration of houses, is divided into four parts by the main axis of communication that reaches the center of the island. Astrological and religious meanings were given to each of these four parts that are associated with different divinities and that are organized in relatively autonomous districts.

Contrary to most cities in Europe at the time, Tenochtitlan's fast growth allowed it to stick to geometrical construction, a feat common for Nahuatl cities of the time whose ruins are still aligned with the stars nowadays. Overall, this care for structuredness is what allowed the Mexican empire to maintain its status: tax collection systems derived from this concern as Camilla Townsend suggests; "the city's four quarters or sub-*altepetls* were further divided along the lines of the *calpolli* [...] each with its own noble (*pilli*) families, in the midst of the commoner (*macehualli*) families"¹. This sort of enforced destiny shows systematic logical reasoning behind the orderedness of the city, which is then further expanded to the entire empire through a number of administrative provinces where local Mexica officials in charge of tax collection worked on

¹ Camilla Townsend, *Fifth Sun: A New History of the Aztecs* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2019), (Chapter 3. The City on the Lake (1470-1518). Page 66

“synchronizing various altepetls’ calendars, so it would be clear when tribute was due”² (Townsend p.72). Having administrative procedures embedded in calendars once again displays the strong connection between sacred and state management but also presents us with another geometrical and organized structure of the Mexican empire. Although calendars are at the limit of the scope of this essay, they reaffirm Tenochtitlan as a structured center of power that bases its authority on its systematic handling of socioeconomic affairs.

Secondly, Tenochtitlán is an expanding metropolis on a lake, which represents a fundamental aspect of its identity and allows it to sustain itself and communicate with the land beyond. We have already mentioned city building before but omitted a central detail: Tenochtitlán is built on a lake, with water being heavily incorporated in urban planning and flowing between houses, in aqueducts and through crops grown in the outskirts of the city. As a transition between the city and the outside world, the lake is far from still. On it, countless shallow boats and small constructions on isolated islands show the never-ending activity of locals that source their food, transport their goods and maintain their health through it. Indeed, if city dwellers could contribute to the growth of their empire and accumulate knowledge of precise craftsmanship,³ it was partly because their basic needs were guaranteed by the symbiosis of aquatic infrastructure. Hygiene for example was taken very seriously with citizens bathing often, and after the population was too important to rely only on the food cultivated on the shores of the island, water was still the solution

² Camilla Townsend, *Fifth Sun: A New History of the Aztecs* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2019), (Chapter 3. The City on the Lake (1470-1518). Page 72

³ Camilla Townsend, *Fifth Sun: A New History of the Aztecs* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2019), (Chapter 3. The City on the Lake (1470-1518). Page 72

as it allowed “[Tenochtitlán's] market to become a great hub of trade, tying together all the peoples who lived near the surrounding lake shores”⁴.

Much like how water flows through the city and is an integrating part of it, trade networks and roads seem to fulfill a similar purpose. The aquatic natural space is depicted in both primary and secondary sources as having been incorporated in Mexican lifestyle, with signs of human dominance over it: large straight bridges defy the less geometrical water and pass over it to link the city with the external component of this map. In fact, numerous towns, some even half afloat on the lake, all face the central city from the outer layer, and if these cannot be considered to be Tenochtitlan, they nonetheless are an essential part of its influence and constitute a part of its glory. Showcasing the direct connection of Tenochtitlán and surrounding vassal or allied cities also breaks the idea of an isolated island: the similar architectural feats and extension over water visible in towns linked to the Empire's capital accentuate the idea of a shared culture and lifestyle. After establishing the fundamental role played by water and the importance of the connections the lake allows Tenochtitlan to explore, we can now ask ourselves about the nature of the relations the city has with its surroundings, symbolized by the outer layer of the map.

Thirdly, the primary source depicts Tenochtitlán as the head of the Mexica Empire, having its origins, but also its opportunities and its threats come from the land around it. According to Mexica myth, after the emergence of humans from the seven caves they were instructed by divine command to move south and settle in what is now central Mexico. The mythological narrative of the Mexican's founding of Tenochtitlan underscores its deep-rooted connection with divine power

⁴ Camilla Townsend, *Fifth Sun: A New History of the Aztecs* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2019), (Chapter 3. The City on the Lake (1470-1518). Page 66

and expansive settlement. If the exact relation of neighboring settlements visible on the map and Tenochtitlán is not apparent on the primary source, the green land represent the context in which this city state emerges: it is at the same time where they come from, what they are concerned with and lastly that which will determines their future, so something to be prepared against. The practical relation of Tenochtitlan and its bordering urban areas is thankfully detailed by Camilla Townsend: she describes the capital of the empire and its main partners as receiving tribute from hundreds of smaller cities around the lake and beyond, with periods of exceptional power even allowing direct control over between 38 and 55 provinces with permanent military garrisons securing trade routes and hence ensuring a relatively peaceful dominance⁵. It can seem strange at first that such powerful hegemony is not depicted on the map, yet its subtle presence is what seems to ensure all its parts belong to a whole. Again, this map of Tenochtitlan is structured like a flower seen from a top view. Each element is facing inwards, towards the center of the map, towards which our attention is directly concentrated. Each house of the outer layer cities, each rock on the green pastures is facing the central figure, as if to illustrate that it is the source and foundation of the Empire's glory and power from which all things derive. Given this explanation, it seems logical that the extent and size of Tenochtitlan's influence is not represented; instead, the focus here is on the legitimate source to which all things converge and from where all things come from.

Nevertheless, as illustrated by the fortified barricade closing off a portion of the map, the expansive interests of the Empire were not left unchecked, and the outer layer of the urban flower is also a source of threat. Foreign army or natural catastrophe, the exact shape of the tragedy is unclear for cartographs of the time, but its uncertainty is visible in the void encircling the floral city: will its organized structure hold against the unknown?

⁵ Camilla Townsend, *Fifth Sun: A New History of the Aztecs* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2019) (Chapter 3. The City on the Lake (1470-1518). Page 74

In conclusion, this essay has shown what kind of structure is put in place in Tenochtitlan and how the connection between the different spaces of the city forms an organized whole. We have looked at administrative power and its strong interdependency with divine order, but also how these affect socio-economic factors throughout the city. Then, we turned to the essential part played by the lake in making this capital a hub for trade but also in sustaining the city dwellers, a similar role played by communication routes that also act as symbols of a symbiotic relation between architecture and nature. Lastly, we went over the outer layer of the flower shaped map that showed the influence of Tenochtitlan over neighboring states, but also revealed its origin and lastly the potential dangers it faced. Overall, the predominant focus of all elements of the primary source all pointing at the center shows the unity and delicate balance of Tenochtitlan.

Arthur Barrier

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extensive stretches of forests, Indians planted maize, beans, pumpkins, and
squash in multi-crop fields that had been further cleared by girdling tre